CHAPTER 1 · PRE-1890 · UNIT 7 IN THE COURSE

Classical

clas·si·cal (noun) the history of something

The World That Had No Word for Retirement

There is a telling absence at the center of this story.

For the vast majority of human history — across agrarian civilizations, through the ancient world, into the medieval period, and well into the early modern era — no word existed for retirement. Not because the concept was poorly understood or culturally suppressed. Because the concept did not exist. You cannot name what has never been imagined, and for roughly five thousand years of recorded human civilization, the idea that a person might stop contributing work to their community and live off accumulated assets was not an aspiration, not a policy debate, and not a moral question. It was simply not a thing.

This is not nostalgia. It is a data point. And it is the data point that makes everything that follows legible.

An Honest Accounting

Before we examine what the classical world got right about aging and contribution, intellectual honesty requires a clear-eyed account of what it got catastrophically wrong about almost everything else.

Life was brutal by any modern measure. In ancient Rome, average life expectancy at birth hovered around 25 to 35 years — not because people routinely died in their thirties, but because infant mortality was so savage that it dragged the average into the ground. Roughly one in three children died before their fifth birthday. Epidemic disease moved through populations with no theory of contagion and no antibiotics to stop it. The Plague of Justinian in the sixth century killed an estimated 25 to 50 million people — perhaps half the Byzantine Empire. The Black Death that swept Europe between 1347 and 1351 killed somewhere between a third and half of the entire continent. Those who survived childhood and plague might live long and vigorous lives. But survival was not guaranteed, and the margin between life and death was thin enough that planning across decades was an exercise in faith more than strategy.

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Physical suffering attended most kinds of labor. The serf who worked a lord's land from dawn to dusk was not building a life of meaning and reciprocal exchange — he was barely surviving inside a system designed to extract everything he produced and return just enough to keep him functional. Women across virtually every classical culture were not participants in systems of reciprocal obligation; they were property within them. In ancient Greece, Rome, and throughout medieval Europe, women could not own land, could not enter contracts, could not inherit in their own names. Widowhood was not a financial challenge — it was financial ruin. Caste systems in South Asia locked entire populations into inherited deprivation from birth, their suffering not an accident of circumstance but a feature of explicit social architecture. Indigenous peoples across the globe operated within functional community systems of their own making, only to have those systems violently dismantled by colonization, dispossession, and forced assimilation.

None of this is in dispute. The classical world was not a golden age. For a very large portion of its human inhabitants, it was defined by poverty, subjugation, disease, and early death.

And yet.

What Suffering Reveals About Structure

Here is what the hardship of the classical world actually illuminates about the three principles that form the interpretive spine of this book — because it illuminates them more sharply than comfort ever could.

When women could not own property, when serfs had no legal standing, when the diseased and disabled had no institutional recourse — they turned to community. Not because community was a policy framework or a philosophical ideal, but because it was the only thing standing between them and annihilation. The widow who could not inherit went to her family. The serf displaced by famine went to his village. The orphaned child went to the parish. The structures were imperfect, often unjust, sometimes catastrophically inadequate. But they existed. They were built into the architecture of daily life not as charity programs but as load-bearing walls.

This is the critical insight: the not poverty principle and the community principle were not luxuries of a comfortable world. They were survival mechanisms of a brutal one. When you have no rights, no safety net, and no individual recourse, community is not optional. It is the mechanism by which people who should have died alone managed not to. The community held the weight precisely because no individual could carry it.

The serfs of medieval England — bound to land they did not own, taxed beyond subsistence, with no legal identity independent of their lord — nonetheless built mutual aid structures within their villages that provided rudimentary support for the sick, the very old, and the newly widowed. The guild systems of medieval Europe were not charitable organizations; they were collective

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insurance mechanisms through which craftsmen pooled risk against sickness, disability, and the death of a breadwinner. These systems were not perfect. They were not just. But they were evidence that the instinct toward community-based risk distribution is not a modern political preference — it is a human response to vulnerability that manifests under pressure.

What the industrial revolution ultimately destroyed was not the injustice — that persisted in new forms — but the community that had been managing its consequences.

The Moral Architecture: Religion, Resistance, and the Ethics of Survival

We cannot understand how people survived the injustice of the classical world without understanding the moral frameworks that made survival possible — and sometimes, made resistance to injustice imaginable.

Every major religious tradition of the classical period addressed the question of obligation to the aged, the poor, and the widow with a directness that modern financial planning has never matched. The Hebrew Bible is unambiguous: caring for the widow, the orphan, and the stranger is not charitable behavior — it is covenant obligation. The ancient Israelite practice of leaving the edges of fields unharvested — the law of pe'ah — was an agricultural welfare system embedded in religious law. It was not voluntary. It was required. To fail it was not merely impractical; it was a violation of one's relationship with God and community simultaneously.

The early Christian church built on this foundation and extended it into institutional form. By the fourth century, the Church operated xenodochia — houses for the poor, the sick, travelers, and the aged — across the Roman Empire. These were not expressions of individual virtue. They were understood as structural obligations of Christian community, funded through tithing, governed through church authority, and sustained across generations. The Islamic tradition formalized this further: zakat, the obligatory almsgiving that constitutes one of the Five Pillars of Islam, was not a suggestion. It was a tax on wealth redistributed to the poor, the orphaned, the indebted, and the displaced. The Buddhist concept of dana — generosity as spiritual practice — created cultural norms around the support of the elderly and infirm that functioned as informal social insurance across Southeast and East Asia for centuries.

What these traditions shared was a refusal to frame the suffering of the vulnerable as a private problem. Poverty was not evidence of individual failure. Aging was not a personal logistical challenge. The community's obligation to its most vulnerable members was a moral claim — backed by divine authority in most traditions — that could not be dissolved by economic convenience or political expediency.

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This is not a detour from the retirement story. It is its foundation. The question of how a society treats its aging and its vulnerable is, at its core, a moral and philosophical question masquerading as a financial one. Every financial system that has ever addressed retirement has been, underneath its actuarial tables and policy frameworks, an implicit moral statement about obligation, community, and what we owe each other across time. The classical world made these obligations explicit, embedded them in religious practice, and — however imperfectly and however unjustly in other dimensions — enforced them through the most powerful motivational architecture in human history: the fear of God and the weight of community judgment.

The crisis we face today is not, at its root, a mathematical problem. It is a moral one. We dismantled the moral architecture that enforced obligation without replacing it with anything of equivalent weight. We substituted a 401(k) for a covenant. We replaced "you owe this to your neighbor" with "you should have saved more." The numbers are bad. But the numbers are downstream of the moral failure.

Working Against the Established Order

There is one more dimension of the classical world that deserves examination before we turn to what industrialization destroyed: the recurring phenomenon of communities actively organizing against unjust systems to protect their most vulnerable members.

The classical world was not passive in its suffering. Precisely because the moral frameworks of religious tradition had articulated what a community owed its members, there existed a basis for identifying — and resisting — arrangements that violated those obligations. Medieval monasteries served not only as spiritual centers but as functioning welfare institutions for the surrounding communities — providing food during famine, care for the sick, education for the poor, and housing for the destitute aged — often in explicit tension with the interests of the local nobility.

Here I always think of one of my favorite childhood cartoons. Disney's 1973 "Robin Hood." Right at the heart of the resistance was the local priest Friar Tuck. One moment that stands out to me is when the last bit of money is taken from the church's poor box, Tuck loses it and picks a fight with the Sheriff of Nottingham and is jailed for treason. Perhaps Christopher Nolan could remake this one.

The networks of mutual aid among Jewish communities in the Diaspora — developed over centuries of legal dispossession and political exclusion — constituted some of the most sophisticated informal insurance systems in pre-modern history. In feudal societies, peasant communities developed elaborate informal systems of labor sharing and resource pooling that protected their most vulnerable members through relationships of reciprocity that no lord could fully control.

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We will see this pattern again. The Americans who built labor unions in the early twentieth century, who fought for Social Security in the 1930s, who established pension systems in the postwar era — they were doing what human communities have always done when the established order fails to honor its obligations: building structures that enforce what the powerful would prefer to ignore. The question we face now, in the early stages of what this book calls the catastrophe, is whether the communities of the twenty-first century still have the moral vocabulary, the structural imagination, and the collective will to do the same thing again.

The classical world, for all its brutality, never stopped trying. That is the tradition we are heir to.

What Work Actually Was

In pre-industrial economies, work was not a discrete category of life that could be turned on or off. It was woven into the fabric of existence the way eating and sleeping were woven in — not a role one held but a relationship one lived inside. The farmer did not "have a job." The blacksmith did not "go to work." The work and the person were not separable in any meaningful way.

This mattered for aging in ways we have largely forgotten. Because work was relational and embedded rather than transactional and extracted, it could evolve. The farmer who could no longer plow could supervise, teach, plan. The craftsman whose hands had slowed could train apprentices, manage accounts, judge quality. The elder who could no longer do what youth does remained a node in a living system of production and meaning. Capacity declined; contribution did not have to.

The Roman paterfamilias held legal and economic authority over his household well into old age, not despite his age but because of it — wisdom, judgment, and accumulated relational capital were understood as forms of productive contribution. In ancient Chinese Confucian culture, the elder's role was not to stop contributing but to shift the nature of the contribution toward governance, counsel, and the transmission of knowledge. In indigenous cultures across multiple continents, elders were not burdens awaiting subsidized care but active custodians of communal memory and decision-making. The details vary; the structure does not.

This was not charity. It was economics.

The Life Expectancy Paradox

There is a number that appears in almost every popular account of retirement history, and it is almost always misused: the average life expectancy of 61 years when Social Security set the retirement age at 65 in 1935. The implication — sometimes stated, more often implied — is that retirement at 65 was essentially end-of-life planning for people who were nearly dead anyway.

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The number is real. The implication is wrong, and understanding why it is wrong matters for how we read the entire classical period.

Average life expectancy in pre-industrial populations was devastated primarily by three factors: infant and child mortality, epidemic disease, and death in childbirth. These were not slow, distributed forms of dying spread across the population. They were catastrophic mortality events concentrated in the very young and in women of reproductive age. If you survived childhood — made it past five, then past fifteen — your statistical outlook improved dramatically. A Roman male who reached age 25 could expect to live, on average, into his mid-fifties or beyond. A medieval European who survived the Black Death and reached thirty had a reasonable chance of seeing sixty. Death lived much nearer to people back then and only in our modern context has it been pushed out of our daily lives where it is now a surprise rather than a common occurrence.

The ancient and medieval world was full of old people. The Venerable Bede lived to sixty-two. Michelangelo worked until he died at eighty-eight. Galileo reached seventy-seven. Thomas Hobbes lived to ninety-one. These were not miraculous outliers. They were people who had made it through the gauntlet of early mortality and then lived out a lifespan not entirely unlike our own.

The notion that pre-industrial societies didn't need to think about aging because everyone died young is a statistical artifact masquerading as history. The real story is more interesting: classical societies thought deeply about aging, built structures to address it, and the structures they built looked nothing like retirement.

What the Absence of Retirement Actually Means

The inequities of the classical world were real, often monstrous, and must not be minimized. Women treated as property. Serfs without legal standing. Caste systems engineering poverty from birth. Populations ravaged by diseases we now prevent with a single vaccination. Moral frameworks invoked to justify oppression as often as to resist it. These are not footnotes to the classical story — they are central to it.

But they do not undermine the structural observation this chapter is making. They intensify it. The community principle was not at work in the classical world because conditions were easy. It was at work because conditions were almost unimaginably hard, and the alternative to community was individual ruin.

What happened beginning around 1890 was not simply that new technology arrived or that economies got more complex. What happened was that industrialization broke all three principles simultaneously — and broke them faster than any human community had ever

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experienced such a rupture. Work became extractive and terminal rather than evolving and embedded. Community structures dissolved under the pressure of urbanization. Elder poverty, which had been a failure mode in the old system, became a design feature of the new one.

Otto von Bismarck's pension in Germany, which we will examine in the next chapter, was not a visionary act of retirement's grand future. It was triage. It was what you do when a river floods and you are handing out sandbags. The flood was industrial capitalism's relationship to aging human bodies. The sandbags were the first retirement systems. And we have been handing out sandbags ever since, calling it a solution — and increasingly, running out of sand.

The classical world did not hand out sandbags. It built on higher ground. The ground was unjust. The ground was brutal. The ground was often soaked in the suffering of those it excluded. But the architecture of mutual obligation that it sustained — the insistence that a community answers for its most vulnerable members, the moral claim that aging is not a private logistical problem but a shared human condition — that architecture is not a relic. It is a blueprint.

Understanding why we came down off that ground — and how the descent was dressed up as progress — is what the rest of this book is about.

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